Roberta Southwood 3/23/25

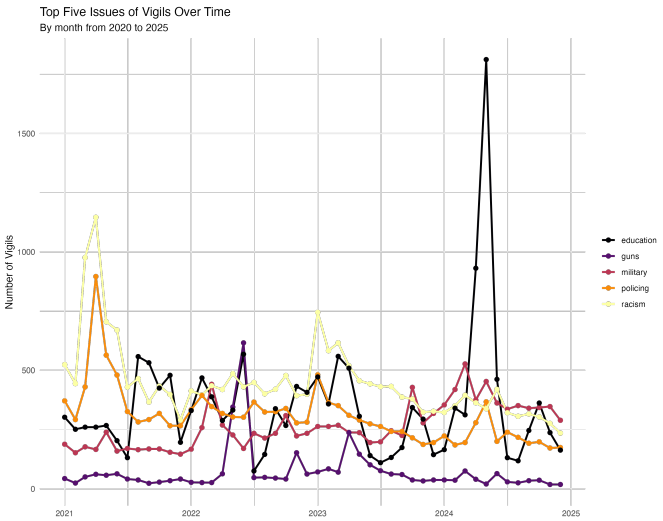


Figure 1: Number of vigils over time for the top five issues with the highest quantity.

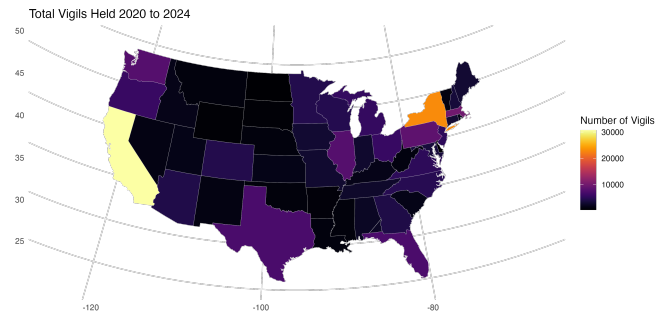
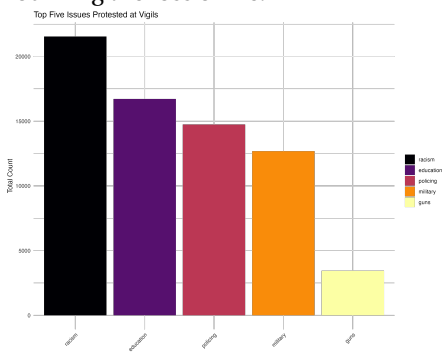


Figure 2: Total vigils held between 2020 and 2024 per US state, excluding Washington DC.

Exploring Vigils as a Type of Protest

The protest form of vigils is often used to address significant issues such as gun violence, racism, and military-related conflicts, and is particularly prevalent in states with notable histories of protests.

The Crowd Counting Consortium dataset presents protest data from 2020 to 2024, and reports the top forms of protest as marches, rallies, demonstrations, and vigils. Vigils, often seen as a less confrontational form of protest, surprisingly rank fourth in popularity. Exploring this form of protest reveals historical roots and its role in mourning the loss of life.



(Figure 3: The five main issues addressed through vigils in the past four years.)

Among the five main issues associated with vigils, it can be inferred that vigils related to racism and police are related to the Black Lives Matter movement that gained momentum in 2020, while those focused on education and gun violence are likely in response to school shootings. Military vigils, on the other hand, advocate for peace and call for an end to wars and global violence. Notably, all of the top five issues are deeply connected to the tragic loss of life, whether through racial violence, gun-related tragedies, or the devastating consequences of war, highlighting the profound human suffering at the heart of these protests.

Figure one shows no major change in trend of the frequency of vigils, however the spikes and dips indicate they are reactionary to current events. The large peak in the graph is from protests about education issues from school bombings in Gaza. This is a limitation of the data set, as these protests could have also been counted as a military vigils.

The Crowd Counting Consortium also has some other limitations in its data recording. Certain protests are not counted due to violence, and the recording method changed between the first period (2017-2020) and the second period (2020-2024). For these reasons, this study focused on a nonviolent form of protest and only examined the second half of the data.

Figure 2 shows that New York and California have a significantly higher volume of vigils compared to other regions. Many universities in California use vigils as a form of protest, contributing to the high numbers, with several universities holding vigils for the same specific issue. California universities have a long history of nonviolent political protests, although these protests receive far less media coverage in recent years. In New York, most of the vigils were in response to police brutality and racism, reflecting the state's long history of activism in these areas as New York has been a focal point for civil rights movements since the 1960's. It is important to note that Washington D.C. is not included in the map due to challenges in manipulating the data, but also has a high volume of protest due to it being the nations capital.

Future research comparing vigils to other forms of protest could be valuable in understanding the effectiveness of vigils as a protest tool. While vigils are less frequently discussed in media or public discourse compared to other protest forms, this study highlights that vigils are actively being used to protest a wide range of political issues.